

The Gamble That Failed

Six seats short of a majority, the Congress will be made vulnerable by the deals it must now strike. And Chautala is breathing down its neck.

By Arvind Chhabra

Having advanced the Assembly elections by about six months, after winning nine of the 10 seats in the Lok Sabha elections, Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda was supposed to have been the runaway leader and the Assembly elections a one-horse race. All

such talk has been silenced by the voters. The Congress may have emerged as the single largest party but the message from the verdict is loud and clear. Voters gave the party 27 seats less than in 2005 and that makes Hooda's position anything but comfortable. Equally, Om Prakash Chautala whose political obituaries were being written lives to fight another day.

Even if Hooda manages to retain his chair, he won't sit easy. Apart from the enemies within, being short of the halfway mark also means that the Congress will have to cut a few political deals to remain in power and even then, possibly be at the mercy of political wheeler-dealers. The Congress defeat, if anything was self-inflicted. Hooda's government was widely seen as a rich man's regime that left out the rural poor. Its campaign was lukewarm, a reflection perhaps of its misplaced sense of confidence. The party failed to guard against infighting which came to the fore during the distribution of tickets. Hooda managed tickets

for his loyalists but incited rebellion in many constituencies.

It is possible that Hooda went in for early polls in the belief the anti-incumbency factor would be heightened a year hence when polls were originally due. But he failed to understand that Lok Sabha and Assembly elections are fought on different issues. The rise in prices since the Lok Sabha polls could only have harmed the party's interests.

Hooda also believed that with the opposition in disarray, early polls would give him an added advantage and was confident of defying history in a state that hasn't returned any party to power in the past three decades. Once the INLD-BJP came apart and other mergers and alliances among opposition parties failed to materialise, Hooda and his advisers were convinced of victory. In fact, the party appeared to have an edge over its rivals till about a week before the elections. Hooda also miscalculated the damage that former chief minister Bhajan Lal's Haryana Janhit Congress could cause. Bhajan Lal and his son Kuldeep

SANJAY KUMAR



HARYANA		Total Seats 90		
PARTIES		SEATS 2009	SEATS 2005	SEATS 2000
 Indian National Congress		40	67	21
 Indian National Lok Dal		31	9	47
 Bharatiya Janata Party		4	2	6
Haryana Janhit Congress (BL)		6	-	-
Independents and Others		9	12	16

In the 2000 elections, INLD and BJP were allies